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The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, intervals of clouds and sunshine, not so chilly, high 53. **Tonight**, cloudy with a bit of rain late, low 42. **Tomorrow**, rain and drizzle, high 48. Weather map appears on Page B8.

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Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00

STRIKES KILLED IRAN SUCCESSORS EYED BY U.S.



IRAN Airstrikes pounded Tehran on Tuesday as President Trump acknowledged uncertainty over what would come next there.

For U.S. Foes, Hard to Find Place to Hide

By DAVID E. SANGER

WASHINGTON — When Nicolás Maduro and his wife walked into their apartment deep in a Caracas military base on an early January morning, they had no way of knowing that their every movement was being tracked by American intelligence. Or that the apartment, including the safe room, had been replicated in Kentucky by a Delta team that did dozens of practice runs figuring out how to immobilize the guards and breach the doors.

Ayatollah Ali Khamenei apparently ignored the evidence that the C.I.A. was tracking him and his top leaders, too, an operation that President Trump exposed in a social media post eight months ago. When the United States and Israel discovered that he and his national security team would be gathering Saturday morning, they advanced the timeline for their attack.

Mr. Maduro is now in the federal detention center in Brooklyn. Ayatollah Khamenei’s state funeral is being planned for the coming days. And the rest of the world’s leaders are left to mull the combination of exquisite American surveillance capabilities and a president who seems to take delight in using that information to capture or kill his perceived enemies.

American intelligence agencies have long wiretapped, geolocated and monitored senior leaders, back to the earliest days of the Cold War. Fifteen years ago, WikiLeaks revelations included docu-

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Initiating War Is Legacy Risk For President

By TYLER PAGER

WASHINGTON — Six American service members were killed, and U.S. military jets were shot out of the sky. Investors are bracing for market turmoil, fearing prolonged disruption to oil supplies. President Trump says the military campaign against Iran could extend for weeks, and Secretary of State Marco Rubio said Monday that “the hardest hits are yet to come from the U.S. military.”

With his decision Friday to authorize war against Iran, Mr. Trump is taking the biggest gamble of his presidency, risking the lives of American troops, more deaths and instability in the world’s most volatile region, and his own political standing.

Mr. Trump, facing declining approval ratings and staring down the possibility that Republicans will lose control of Congress in the midterms, plunged the United States into what is shaping up to be its most expansive military conflict since the 2003 invasion of Iraq.

In just over a year since taking office, Mr. Trump has authorized military action in seven nations, even after he repeatedly promised American voters that he would end, not start, wars. During his inaugural address, he said his “proudest legacy will be that of a peacemaker.”

Even as he has struggled to provide a clear endgame for the

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LEBANON The Israeli military struck Dahiyeh, a suburb of Beirut, and said it had occupied “strategic” southern areas of the nation.



KUWAIT Mourners carried the bodies of troops killed in an Iranian strike. The U.S. closed embassies in Kuwait and Saudi Arabia.



UNITED ARAB EMIRATES An explosion in the Fujairah Oil Industry Zone, a significant energy hub. Oil and gas prices have surged.

As War Escalates, Trump Warns of a Leader ‘as Bad’ as the Ayatollah

This article is by Jim Tankersley, Aaron Boxerman, Christina Goldbaum and Michael Levenson.

As the war in the Middle East expands, President Trump on Tuesday acknowledged the deep uncertainty about what comes next in Iran, saying that officials whom the United States had eyed as potential new leaders had been killed in the U.S.-Israeli bombing campaign.

“Most of the people we had in mind are dead,” Mr. Trump said at the start of a White House meeting with Chancellor Friedrich Merz of Germany. He said it was possible that whoever takes over Iran could be “as bad” as Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the country’s supreme leader, who was killed in a strike on Saturday.

Mr. Trump’s comments came as Israeli troops seized more areas in southern Lebanon and called for the evacuation of at least 80 Lebanese villages. The Israeli military cast the move as an effort to defend Israeli border towns against rockets fired by Hezbollah, the militia backed by Iran.

Israeli warplanes also carried out heavy airstrikes near Beirut, the Lebanese capital, and Tehran, the Iranian capital.

The United States closed embassies that were hit by drones in Saudi Arabia and Kuwait and urged Americans to immediately leave 14 Middle Eastern countries. Iran’s state broadcaster, IRIB, said an Iranian drone had also hit the area of the U.S. Consulate in Dubai. The government-run Dubai media office said that a fire from a “drone-related incident” near the consulate had been contained and that no injuries were reported.

Mr. Trump has offered several rationales for the American military operation. The president said at the White House on Tuesday that he had made the decision to go to war to pre-empt Iran, which

he claimed was about to attack. Officials with access to U.S. intelligence have said that Mr. Trump has exaggerated the immediacy of any threat Iran posed to the United States.

“We were having negotiations with these lunatics, and it was my opinion that they were going to attack,” Mr. Trump said. Asked if Israel had forced his hand, as has been widely reported, he said, “If anything, I might have forced Israel’s hand.”

In a legally mandated notification to Congress sent later on Tuesday, Mr. Trump said the strikes on Iran were being carried out to protect the United States at home, as well as its forces in the Middle East; to advance U.S. national interests; and “in collective self-defense of our regional allies, including Israel.”

He said he had no timeline for the end of the assault.

“Although the United States desires a quick and enduring peace, it is not possible at this time to know the full scope and duration of military operations that may be necessary,” Mr. Trump wrote in

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Chancellor Friedrich Merz of Germany visited Mr. Trump.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Iran Aims to Play Long Game And Force U.S. to Pay Dearly

By STEVEN ERLANGER

BERLIN — The Islamic Republic of Iran’s first priority is to survive. To do that, its leaders will want to drive up the cost of the war for President Trump — in terms of American casualties, energy costs and inflation — to try to persuade him to declare victory and go home.

Faced with the overwhelming firepower of the United States and Israel, diplomats and analysts say, Iran is working to enlarge the battlefield from its own territory to the broader region. The goals are to damage oil and gas infrastructure in neighboring countries, shut the Strait of Hormuz to shipping and curtail air traffic — all to disrupt the economies of the Persian Gulf and drive up global energy prices and inflation. Iran will also be trying to exhaust the number of expensive missile interceptors held by its enemies.

“The war has become a test of wills and stamina,” said Vali Nasr of the Johns Hopkins School of Advanced International Studies in Washington. “Iran is facing qualitatively superior militaries,

so the strategy is to test their will by expanding the battlefield, complicating the war and increasing the danger to the world economy.”

The strategy is not complicated.

Ali Vaez, the Iran director of the Brussels-based think tank International Crisis Group, said, “The Iranians want to spread the pain as much as they can, regardless of the cost to themselves and burned relations with their neighbors, hoping to create enough opposition to the war to compel President Trump to back off.”

“For the Islamic Republic,” he added, “survival is a victory, even if it is a Pyrrhic one.”

The plan is so-called asymmetric endurance, accepting initial damage to preserve the ability to escalate when Israeli, American and Persian Gulf air defenses are stretched thin. The thinking behind that strategy is that Mr. Trump, facing midterm elections and a skeptical MAGA move-

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The Bloody Rise and Fall of Mexico’s Mob Boss

This article is by Jack Nicas, Paulina Villegas and Maria Abi-Habib.

MEXICO CITY — El Mencho, arguably the world’s most powerful criminal, did not have a cellphone.

Worried the devices would expose his location, he relied on human messengers to manage a sprawling criminal organization that stretched across Mexico and into 40 countries, senior Mexican officials said. He issued his orders from shifting encampments in the wooded hills of western Mexico, surrounded by what the authori-

Fugitive for 2 Decades With Achilles’ Heel: His Loved Ones

ties say were at least 60 men and an arsenal of military-grade weapons.

His life hiding in the forest belied the fact that he was one of Mexico’s richest men. Such discipline kept El Mencho — a former police officer turned hit man whose legal name was Rubén Osaguera Cervantes — at large for

two decades.

That was until last week, officials said, when the Mexican authorities took advantage of a weakness: the women in his life.

Mr. Osaguera, 59, wanted to see his adult daughters, they said. So he recently moved into a home in a gated community outside Tapalpa, a touristy Mexican ranch town, bringing a much smaller set of bodyguards.

Then he invited over one of his lovers, officials said — unaware that Mexican intelligence had been tracking her.

On Thursday, Feb. 20, Mexican

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New York City Congestion Pricing Wins in Court

By STEFANOS CHEN and WINNIE HU

A federal judge on Tuesday ruled that the federal government’s attempt to end New York’s congestion pricing toll was illegal, handing a major victory to the state in its defense of the first-in-the-nation traffic reduction plan, which the Trump administration had tried for more than a year to kill.

While other legal challenges remain, the 149-page decision by Judge Lewis J. Liman of Federal District Court in Manhattan ends, for now, a heated battle between

Administration’s Efforts to Kill Program Are Ruled Illegal

Gov. Kathy Hochul, who has become a staunch defender of the program, and the White House, which has claimed, without offering evidence, that it would harm the region’s economy.

The ruling comes months after Judge Liman granted the toll program temporary protection from threats issued by the transporta-

tion secretary, Sean Duffy, who had warned that the federal government would withhold approval and funding from a range of highway and transit projects in New York if congestion pricing was not canceled.

Judge Liman, who had signaled skepticism toward the federal government’s argument that it could unilaterally reverse approval for the toll, said the government’s steps to kill congestion pricing and its subsequent threats to the state’s transportation budget were impermissible.

“It would be difficult to imagine

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